

Xudong Zhu

Ph.D. Candidate in International History, University of Aberdeen

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

International history of great-power strategy and the global order; Sino-European and Sino-American relations from the interwar period to the present; theories of empire and international order; applied history and contemporary grand strategy.

EDUCATION

University of Aberdeen

Aberdeen, UK

Ph.D. Candidate in International History

Mar. 2025 – Present

- Supervisors: Prof. Dr. Thomas Weber; Dr. Andrew Dilley.
- Fields: applied history, grand strategy, global security.

Ruprecht-Karls-Universität Heidelberg

Heidelberg, Germany

M.A. in American Studies (Political Science and History track)

Oct. 2021 – Aug. 2023

- Thesis: *On the Theory of Empire in International Relations and an Analysis of Pax Americana*.
- Coursework included U.S. economic policy, the Transatlantic alliance, nuclear deterrence theory, political psychology, and varieties of American conservatism.

Jilin University

Changchun, China

LL.B. in Diplomacy

Sep. 2017 – Jun. 2021

- Coursework included international history, international-relations theory, international law, power politics, and political philosophy.

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

- Royal Historical Society — Postgraduate Member (2025–).
- Association of Chinese Political Studies — Member (2025–).

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Book Chapter

- Wang, L., and **Zhu, X.** “How to Maintain a Balance in the Intricate *Pas de Trois* among China, US and EU.” In *The Trilateral Interactions: China, the US, and the EU on Tensions, Competition, and Cooperation*, edited by Zuokui Liu, Marek Hrubec, and Shaohua Yan. London: Routledge, 2026. [doi:10.4324/9781003736554-8](https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003736554-8).

Conference Papers

- **Zhu, X.** “Beyond Divide and Rule: Advocating a Respect-Based Chinese Policy Toward the European Union.” Annual Conference of the Association of Chinese Political Studies (ACPS), 20 November 2025. [<https://abdn.elsevierpure.com/en/publications/ff9b30a6-1b2b-40b0-bc3b-2ef41e4d4234>].
- **Zhu, X.** “What to Do About the Strategic Challenge? An Analysis of the Background of NATO’s New China Strategy.” Seventh Annual Young Scholars Forum on U.S.–China Relations, The Carter Center, 2022.

Prize Essay

- **Zhu, X.** “Trump as the (In)advertent Harbinger of a New Transatlantic Security Architecture: Europe’s Autonomy as a Bulwark Against Chinese Influence.” **Runner-up, Jimmy Carter Prize**, China Focus Essay Contest, 2025. [<https://uscnpm.org/2025/08/12/europe-autonomy-against-chinese-influence/>].

Public Scholarship and Commentary

Contributing Writer, U.S.–China Perception Monitor (The Carter Center), Selected Articles:

- “Improving U.S.–China Relations: Ten Thousand Years Is Too Long; Seize The Day” 18 May 2026. [<https://uscnpm.org/analysis/improving-u-s-china-relations/>]. (English)
- “If Bismarck Ran Washington: What Approach Would He Take to U.S.–China Relations?” 11 December 2025. [<https://zmyx.info/if-bismarck-directed-china-policy-in-washington/>]. (Chinese)
- “From ‘The Art of the Deal’ to ‘The Art of Diplomacy’: The Continuities in Trump’s View of International Relations.” 11 September 2025. [<https://zmyx.info/on-trump-interview-with-playboy-in-1990/>]. (Chinese)

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of Aberdeen

Aberdeen, UK

Teaching Assistant

2025/26

- HI1022 *Europe in the Twentieth Century*.
- HI2520 *Global Empire in the Long Nineteenth Century*.

Ruprecht-Karls-Universität Heidelberg

Heidelberg, Germany

Tutor

Summer Semester 2023

- *From Washington to Peking: A History of Early Interactions Between the U.S. and China*: led seminar discussions on Sino-American relations (1784–1882), covering trade, diplomacy, and labour migration, with attention to China's integration into the nineteenth-century international order.

DIGITAL HUMANITIES PROJECTS

BismAI: A Bismarck-Persona Fine-Tune of Gemma 4 E4B

2026

Sole author | huggingface.co/Ottomin/BismAI-V2

- LoRA fine-tune of Google's Gemma 4 E4B Instruct base model (~7B parameters), trained to adopt the rhetorical and strategic voice of Otto von Bismarck for historical-persona research and teaching.

PROFESSIONAL AND RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

University of Aberdeen — Experience, Engagement & Wellbeing Team

Aberdeen, UK

Research Intern

Jun. 2025 – Aug. 2025

- Conducted qualitative research on the study journeys of international students (undergraduate, postgraduate-taught, and ISC/Language Centre cohorts); produced strategy roadmaps to enhance the student experience.
- Coordinated communication across academic and professional-services departments and contributed to orientation materials for incoming international students.

The Carter Center — U.S.–China Perception Monitor

Atlanta, USA (Remote)

Academic Assistant

Jun. 2020 – Sep. 2020

- Translated and edited articles on U.S.–China relations for the centre's bilingual platform.
- Co-organised eight academic conferences and authored proceedings summaries.
- Conducted interviews with policy scholars and authored articles averaging over 5,000 readers.

Earlier research experience: University of Tübingen — “International and European Studies” programme (2019); Rutgers, The State University of New Jersey — summer programme (2018); Jilin University — Field study along the China-North Korea border regarding National Security and Border Control (2017).

LANGUAGES

Chinese (native), English (proficient), German (proficient).

AWARDS

- **Runner-up, Jimmy Carter Prize**, China Focus Essay Contest (2025)
- **Excellence Award**, 16th National Diplomatic Etiquette Competition (2018).
- **Best Negotiator**, 3rd Simulated Diplomatic Negotiation Competition, Jilin University (2018).
- **Diplomatic Award**, 1st Simulated Diplomatic Spokesperson Competition, Jilin University (2017).

RESEARCH AND TECHNICAL SKILLS

- **Primary-source research:** archival and documentary research in Chinese, English, and German across diplomatic, military, and political collections.
- **Machine learning and large language models:** fine-tuning of LLMs using LoRA, QLoRA, and supervised fine-tuning (SFT); design and deployment of retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) pipelines.
- **Quantitative methods:** descriptive and inferential statistical analysis in Python, R and SPSS.
- **Document preparation:** L^AT_EX and Markdown for academic writing and typesetting.

SERVICE

- Moderator, Academic Forum at the School of International and Public Affairs (SIPA), Jilin University.
- Research assistant to Prof. Swaran Singh (Jawaharlal Nehru University) during his visit to Jilin University.